



Ready to fire

North Vietnamese forces line up, ready to fire, during a training exercise in Bach Dang in July 1966. The NVA practiced tactical maneuvers and field exercises, hoping to make up for its lack of firepower by keeping its men well-prepared and well-disciplined.

Patriotic society

In the 1960s and 1970s, war was all many North Vietnamese youth had ever known—against Japan, France, and now the United States. North Vietnam’s one-party government ensured that the communists had no opposition. Northerners received information about the world—and the war—exclusively through state-controlled media that reinforced the patriotic necessity of compliant support.

All of North Vietnam was mobilized for war. Primary school children were inculcated in a love for “Uncle Ho” and loyalty to the communist party; teenage Youth Volunteers cleared the Ho Chi Minh Trail of mines for years on end; elderly men served in village civil defense units that assisted with the aftermath of US bombing raids. The picture North Vietnam presented to the world was of unity and determination, even as its people endured grief, frustration, and exhaustion.

700 **BILLION DOLLARS** The sum given to the NVA by the Soviet Union in 1967 alone, far surpassing China’s contributions.